

beings from stories and fables walk among them. They might deny it if someone asks — after all, who wants to be seen as someone crazy enough to believe in faeries — but they cross their fingers behind their backs when they do. They *know*, and the faeries see them.

Changeling: The Dreaming is the story of Kithain, faeries in exile, who're the only line of defense between a vibrant and creative world, and one ruled by nightmares or stagnation. Adventure, political intrigues, tragedy, and uninhibited excitement fills their lives. They're myths and legends brought to life, and the Dreaming awaits *your* tale.

Changelings

Old legends define a changeling as the offspring of mortals and faeries, or a faerie child switched out for a human one. Modern changelings — *Kithain* — are neither of these, but bear similarities to both.

Two Worlds, One Life

Once upon a time, Dreamers and the denizens of their dreams shared a single world. Among these denizens were the faeries, who ruled the world through both kindness and terror. While the fae went to war, humanity slowly turned their backs on the old ways and embraced disbelief and self-reliance. Through this, Banality, a force manifested by the new order, split the worlds into two — the Autumn world and the Dreaming. In the Dreaming all things remain possible. Ancient curses affect entire landscapes, monsters hide in withered forests, roads made of stardust allows travelers to visit vistas hidden among clouds, and ancient dragons and bygone beasts still roam the skies.

In the wake of the Black Plague, however, increasing Banality made it impossible for the Dreaming to maintain connections with the Autumn world, forcing it to close down the majority of pathways. In order to survive this onslaught on their very essence, the fae turned to an ancient ritual which locked their immortal souls in human bodies. This limited access to Glamour — the essence of the Dreaming — forced fae into a cycle of rebirth and rediscovery.

This progression continues even today, but every modern changeling believes that these are the final moments of Autumn, and the Long Winter, a period when Banality covers the world and humanity ceases to dream, is soon upon them.

Chrysalis and the Dream Dance

Faerie souls remain dormant inside changelings until the Dreaming successfully reaches out and touches them, inspiring their true selves to emerge. Mortals can live and die without having their changeling aspect awaken, especially in the modern, Banal age. Those changelings fortunate enough to awaken find their surroundings gradually changing. Suddenly it's possible to pierce the dampening cover of Banality and spot the chimerical qualities hidden in the world around them. It may be something as simple as seeing something others won't perceive, or hearing the conversation of chimerical creatures but being unable to deduce the source of the voices. Unfortunately, many of the



The Arcadian Dream



According to Kithain memories, Arcadia is the homeland of all things faerie, where Banality and mortal bodies are but horrifying nightmares to scare childlings. All changelings have at least a few memories from having lived there during the previous ages, but no changeling knows how much of this remembrance is real and how much is wishful thinking or fancy. In the end, though, it doesn't much matter — what is “real,” when discussing dreams? Besides, these memories of Arcadia serve as hope for the Kithain, hope that the Long Winter can be averted, or at least endured, and that the gates to their homeland will open once again.



signs of impending awakening as a changeling are also signs of various mental illnesses, and in years past, these signs were viewed as supernatural interference or demonic possession. For centuries, then, incipient changelings have found it wise to conceal their experiences.

Eventually, the visions and odd experiences all climax in a burst of Glamour, as memories of past lives return and the faerie spirit emerges from its slumber. This moment of the Chrysalis (the awakening process), is known as the Dream Dance. For a brief moment the changeling achieves perfect clarity of her past before it fades away, leaving the newly awakened ready to rediscover her true self and accept a place in, or outside, faerie society and the two courts. Other Kithain can sense a nascent changeling in the midst of the Dream Dance from miles away, and tradition demands that they stop what they are doing and help the new fae through the process.

Chimerical Quality

Changelings and mortals live in the Autumn world, but many objects, individuals, and locations have a secondary appearance or function only visible and available to those with faerie sight. Changelings refer to this as having chimerical quality.

An old ladle bought at a garage sale, only to end up in the kitchen drawer, may be exactly what it appears at first sight. Nevertheless, if used by a renowned chef creating her *pièce de résistance*, the ladle may have been in her presence when Glamour surged, thus allowing the tool to absorb enough of the Dreaming to bring forth its chimerical quality. Instead of being tarnished and held together by scotch tape, the ladle appears to be made out of radiant gold, with steam clouds engraved along the handle. Mortals viewing a beautiful umbrella are unaware that they're actually looking at the local lord's personal chimerical sword, or that the taxi they're riding in is really shimmering in various colors, depending on its speed. Locations with chimerical qualities are normally freeholds to Kithain, but may also be places that are well visited for having a specific, and strong, meaning to humanity.